Eliminating Agree

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Abstract: I argue for eliminating the operation of Agree. Agreement in natural language is instead analyzed in terms of external Merge of agreement morphemes and the theory of copies and repetitions developed in Chomsky 2024.

Keywords: Agree, Merge, copies, repetitions

1. Agree

Chomsky 2000, 2001 proposed the Agree operation, in part to account for subject-verb agreement illustrated below (see Deal 2023 for systematic presentation of Chomsky's system, and for a useful summary of more recent work on the topic):

(1) a. John call-s Mary every day.
    b. They call-∅ Mary every day.

Features such as person, number and gender are called phi-features. In the present tense, when the subject is 3SG, the verb takes on the *-s* suffix as illustrated in (1a). For all other person number combinations, the verb takes a zero suffix, as illustrated in (1b).

Chomsky proposed that the agreement features on the verb in (1) are unvalued:

(2) "The natural principle is that the uninterpretable features, and only these, enter the derivation without values, and are distinguished from the interpretable features by virtue of this property. Their values are determined by Agree, at which point the features must be deleted from the narrow syntax (or they will be indistinguishable from interpretable features at LF) but left available for phonology (since they may have phonetic effects)." (Chomsky 2001)

In Chomsky's system, there is a probe (a set of unvalued phi-features [uPhi]) that searches its c-command domain to find matching valued phi-features on a goal, illustrated below.

(3)	Probe	Goal
	[uPhi]	Phi of DP
	unvalued	valued

Concretely, in the case of (1), we have the following structure:

(4) $[_{TP}$ T[uPhi] $[_{vP}$ DP $[_{v}$ VP]]]

The unvalued phi-features (uPhi) of the probe search down in the tree and find matching valued phi-features on the subject DP (in Spec vP). The unvalued phi-features of T are valued by the operation Agree(uPhi, DP).

In this paper, I propose to eliminate the operation Agree. Verbal agreement in English will be analyzed as the result of external Merge of agreement morphemes, and the interpretation of multiple sets of phi-features as copies, adopting the analysis of copies and repetitions in Chomsky (2024).

Similar analyses to the one presented here include Collins (2017), Blümel (2023) and Roberts (2024) (Blümel focuses on null subject languages). See also Milway 2023 for a formalization of current models of Agree and an insightful discussion of formal problems that arise. For relevant discussion of Agree, see also Seely 2014 and Epstein, Kitahara and Seely 2018.

2. Parallels between Agree and Internal Merge

For Chomsky (2000, 2001) Merge and Agree are two completely different operations. Neither one is defined in terms of the other.

But there are deep parallels between Agree and internal Merge that are left unaccounted for. For example, in Agree, the probe c-commands the goal. In exactly the same way, if a DP undergoes internal Merge, one occurrence c-commands the other. In other words, both internal Merge and Agree are subject to a c-command condition.

More strikingly, with Agree, the valued phi-features of the goal are copied from one position to the other (valuing the unvalued phi-features of the probe). As a consequence, that set of phi-features has two different occurrences (positions in a structure). This copying operation is similar to internal Merge, where one syntactic object is merged in two different positions. It is as if the phi-features have been internally merged, but Merge is not in any way a part of the definition of Agree.

I highlight these two parallels below, but there are others as welll (e.g., locality, interpretation at the CI-Interface, etc.).

(5)		**internal Merge**		**Agree**	
a.	obeys c-command	yes		yes	
b.	creates copies	yes	(of XP)	yes	(of Phi)

Since internal Merge and Agree have significant structural overlap, it is worthwhile considering whether one of the two can be eliminated: either internal Merge could be eliminated or Agree could be eliminated.

Consider first whether it is possible to eliminate internal Merge. There is no independent operation of internal Merge, there is only Merge, which has two subcases: internal and external. But Merge is indispensable as a syntactic operation. It is what allows the language faculty to generate an unlimited number of expressions, given the finite means of the human mind/brain. Therefore, it is not possible to eliminate internal Merge (because one would have to eliminate the indispensable operation Merge), so I propose that Agree should be eliminated instead (for the same conclusion, see Collins 2017: 65).

The null hypothesis is that there are no syntactic operations other than Merge as part of UG. An additional operation would go against the SMT (Strong Minimalist Thesis). Hence eliminating Agree also conforms with the SMT.

3. Copies and Repetitions

Collins and Groat (2018) systematically discuss the problems in determining the difference between copies and repetitions at the interfaces. Consider the following two structures:

(6) John was seen <John>. (IM of 'John' in Spec TP)
{John, {T, {be, {seen, John}}}}

(7) John saw John. (EM of 'John' in Spec vP)
{John, {v, {see, John}}}

In (6), *John* has undergone internal Merge in the passive, yielding two copies. In (7), *John* is externally merged into Spec vP, yielding two different repetitions. The general question is how to distinguish copies from repetitions at the interfaces. See Collins and Groat (2018), Chomsky (2021) and Chomsky (2024) for much discussion.

Chomsky (2024) (henceforth MC) proposes a new theory of copies and repetitions (for a presentation of MC and some modifications see Kitahara and Seely 2023, 2024, see Blümel and Collins 2025 for an overview of MC). Simplifying a bit, the theory given is the following (see also Groat 2013 for a related theory):

(8) X and Y are copies iff
 a. X and Y are structurally identical.
 b. X c-commands Y.
 c. The relationship between X and Y obeys the PIC.

I follow Chomsky (2024: 22-23) in assuming that there is no separate operation of Form Copy: "Earlier work (e.g., GK) postulated an operation FormCopy FC which establishes the copy relation in a cc-configuration. We can adopt FC for convenience, but it has no further status; it need not be considered an admissible operation."

Consider how the theory works in some simple cases. First, consider the passive in (6). Since all conditions (identity, c-command and PIC) are met, the two occurrences are copies. Now consider (7). Crucially in MC, [v…] is a phase boundary, so the two occurrences are repetitions. See Collins 2017 for a related theory.

As it turns out, Chomsky's theory dissociates internal Merge and copies. That is, there are some copies that are not the result of internal Merge. In particular, Chomsky argues that obligatory control and ATB movement are cases involving copies not created by internal Merge. In summary, we have (MC = Miracle Creed):

(9)	a.	If X and Y are related by IM, they are copies.	MC: YES
	b.	If X and Y are repetitions, they are not related by IM.	MC: YES
	c.	If X and Y are copies, they are related by IM.	MC: NO
	d.	If X and Y are not related by IM, they are repetitions.	MC: NO

This dissociation in (9c,d) leads to my central proposal:

(10) Verbal agreement is an externally merged Phi
that is interpreted as a copy of the phi-features of a DP.

By 'verbal agreement', I mean the agreement found on the finite verb in examples like (1) above. In other words, in example (1a) above, the morpheme 3SG *-s* on the finite verb is externally merged and then interpreted as a copy (copy formation) of the 3SG phi-features of the DP *John*.

I will give a full account of my theory in the next section. An immediate consequence of my proposal is (see Collins 2017 for a similar conclusion):

(11) There is no operation Agree in UG.

As a corollary, we have the following consequence, which I will return to below in section 6:

(12) There are no unvalued phi-features.

The distinction between valued and unvalued features was introduced in Chomsky 2001 ("Derivation by Phase"), as seen in the quote in (2). Chomsky 2000 ("Minimalist Inquiries") did not have unvalued features (the word 'unvalued' does not appear in Chomsky 2000). In that way, Chomsky 2000 is closer to the system being developed here. The difference between the current system and Chomsky 2000, is that the latter introduced the Agree operation, which is being eliminated here.

4. Eliminating Agree

In this section, I will give sample derivations showing how my analysis of agreement works. The effects of Agree are completely captured by external Merge and the definition of copies from MC.

I make the simplifying assumption that the phi-features of the DP are located on D (written D[phi]). It would be more accurate to say that the phi-features of the DP are distributed throughout the DP as individual functional projections (e.g., the number feature is found in the Num head, gender is found in a Gen head, etc.).

I assume that verbal phi-features are externally merged into the derivation as a unit, which I will call Phi (for an alternative, see Shlonsky 2023).

(13) Phi is externally merged into the derivation as a unit (not by individual phi-feature).

There are a number of different implementations of this idea compatible with my general approach. First, the phi-features could be directly merged with T: Merge(T, Phi) = {T, Phi}, which is equivalent to saying that T bears phi-features. Another possibility is that the phi-features are introduced as the head of AgrsP ('subject agreement phrase'). I choose the latter for the sake of convenience. In addition, I leave aside the important question of how Phi is associated with finite T in English (e.g., via head movement or some other process).

Given these assumptions, consider now the sentence (14a) with the schematic representation in (14b):

(14) a. He does too run.
b. $[_{\text{AgrsP}}$ Agrs[3SG] $[_{\text{vP}}$ DP[3SG] [v VP]]]

In the theory I am outlining here, neither set of phi-features is unvalued in (14b): there is no Agree operation and no valuing of unvalued phi-features. They are both fully valued sets of phi-features, which I write as 3SG. Writing this more concretely in terms of features and values, we have: {Person: 3, Number: SG}. Privative representations should be possible as well (see Storment 2024). See section 6 below for more on the structural representation of phi-features.

Since the two sets of phi-features are in the right relationship in (14), they are copies, not repetitions (see (8)). Recall that copies are defined in terms of structural identity, c-command and the PIC: First, the two sets of phi-features are structurally identical (they are both third singular). I implicitly assume here that a difference in phonetic value between *-s* and *he* does not block interpretation as copies. Second, the verbal 3SG c-commands DP[3SG], because DP[3SG] is contained in the sister of Agrs[3SG]. Third, since DP[3SG] is in Spec vP, there is no violation of the PIC, Spec vP being the edge of the phase.

As a consequence, at the interfaces, the two sets of phi-features in (14b) are analyzed as copies (copy formation), not as repetitions (see Collins and Stabler 2016 for a formalization of the SM-Interface). No operation Agree was invoked to achieve this result. It follows from the definition of copy in (8).

At the CI-Interface, since the two occurrences of 3SG are interpreted as copies in (14b), they do not refer to different people. For comparison consider:

(15) He thinks that he is nice.

In this example, the two pronouns are 3SG, but they may refer to different people (e.g., John and Bill). That is because the two identical pronouns are separated by a phase boundary (CP) and so are interpreted as repetitions, not copies by (8).

Concretely, I assume that the interpretation of the copies in (14b) at the CI-Interface is done by a kind of total reconstruction: only the lowest copy is interpreted, and the highest copy (the verbal agreement) is simply ignored at the CI-Interface. I suggest that this process is entirely parallel to the process of scope reconstruction for A-movement found in sentences like: *Everybody isn't present*. In this sentence, there is an interpretation where the universal quantifier is interpreted in the scope of negation ($\neg > \forall$) (see McCloskey 1997: 207). I assume that such an interpretation results from the higher copy (created by A-movement) being ignored at the CI-Interface. As McCloskey (1997: 207) puts it: "It is, in turn, a well-known property of the relation established by A-Movement that the moved nominal phrase may make its semantic contribution either at the head or at the tail of the A-chain so formed…".

In other words, my theory of agreement (eliminating Agree) allows us to draw interesting parallels between agreement and other kinds of copy related phenomena (such as scope reconstruction in A-movement).

Now suppose that the 3SG verbal agreement morpheme is merged, but there is no agreement with a DP, as shown in (16a):

(16) a. *They does too run.
b. [$_{\text{AgrsP}}$ Agrs[3SG] [$_{\text{vP}}$ they[3PL] [v VP]]]

In the example in (16a), there is no DP that the verbal agreement 3SG can form a copy with. So there is no copy relation. For example, the verbal agreement 3SG is introduced by external Merge, but it is not in a Theta-Position. Therefore, it should violate the Theta-Criterion. More generally, it should violate Full Interpretation at the CI-Interface. See Chomsky (1986: 98): "…there is a principle of full interpretation (FI) that requires that every element of PF and LF, taken to be the interface of syntax (in the broad sense) with systems of language use, must receive an appropriate interpretation -- must be licensed in the sense indicated. None can simply be disregarded." In other words, (16) is unacceptable because there has been no copy formation between Agrs[3SG] and they[3PL], and therefore Agrs[3SG] violates Full Interpretation.

Suppose that no verbal agreement morpheme is merged in, giving rise to (17a), which is represented in (17b) (Note: There is no AgrsP or Agrs in the structure):

(17) a. *He do too run.
b. *[$_{\text{TP}}$ [T [$_{\text{vP}}$ DP[3SG] [v VP]]]]

I assume that this structure is ruled out in English because finite T requires verbal agreement. As in Chomsky 2013, it may be that such verbal agreement morphemes are needed for the labeling algorithm. It may also be that in certain languages; no such agreement morpheme is necessary in certain circumstances. I have nothing to add to the issue here.

5. The SM-Interface (Externalization)

Returning to (14), what happens at the SM-Interface?

Normally, when copies are created (e.g., by IM), only one of the copies is spelled-out, by economy. For example, in the passive in (6), only the highest copy of *John* is spelled-out, not the lowest (for a formal mechanism, see Collins and Stabler 2016). The result is sometimes called copy-deletion, but in the framework described here, there is no actual deletion (rather, one occurrence is pronounced, but the other one is not).

In the case of agreement, it seems that both copies are pronounced. To be concrete, consider the following structure (repeated from (14)):

(18) a. He does too run.
b. [$_{AgrsP}$ Agrs[3SG] [$_{vP}$ DP[3SG] [v VP]]]

The upper set of phi-features 3SG in (18b) is spelled-out as *-s* (of *does*). The lower set of phi-features is spelled-out as the pronoun *he*. This is an important difference from IM. In IM, the lowest copy is not pronounced. In agreement, both copies are pronounced. How can this difference between IM and agreement be explained?

There are at least two differences between the two occurrences of 3SG in (18) that might be relevant. In the passive in (6), the higher occurrence has nominative Case, and the lower occurrence (which is not pronounced) is plausibly identical, also having nominative Case. In (18), the verbal agreement 3SG does not have any Case at all (it is an agreement suffix showing no Case distinctions), but the lower occurrence (the DP in Spec vP) does have Nominative Case. This difference is paralleled by another difference. The overt pronoun is a DP in (18), but it is not clear that the verbal agreement 3SG is a DP. Rather, the verbal agreement seems to lack a D head. These comparisons are summarized in (19) below

		Higher Occurrence		Lower Occurrence	
(19)	IM (6):	he	Nom/DP	he	Nom/DP
	Agreement (18b):	-s	no Case/no DP	he	Nom/DP

As a result, in (6) there is complete identity between two DPs, and the lower one is not pronounced. In (18), there is identity between phi-features, but not between DPs. And so the DP (hosting the phi-features) needs to be pronounced.

The fact that verbal agreement in English is not a full DP and is totally reconstructed (see section 4) predicts that verbal agreement will not play a role in binding theory phenomena. For example, verbal agreement should not be able to bind a reflexive, or give rise to a Condition B effect, or be bound by an antecedent. As far as I know, all of these predictions of my theory hold.

A next step in the research program outlined in this paper would be to show that the spell-out of copies in verbal agreement falls under the same kind of constraints allowing multiple copies to be spelled-out in movement (on the general issue, Kandybowicz 2007).

I leave the case of pro-drop for further work. Blümel (2023) gives an analysis of pro-drop in terms of copies very similar to my account of agreement in general. I speculate:

(20) In a pro-drop language, verbal agreement and the DP subject pronoun are copies.

In other words, there is some difference between verbal agreement in English and verbal agreement in Italian, such that only the latter leads to non-pronounced pronoun (pro-drop). I will leave to future work how exactly (20) holds.

6. Minimal Search

In this section, I will argue that the copy relation is constrained by minimal search.

Suppose now that there are two DPs in the same phase as the 3SG verbal agreement, only one of them matching with the verbal agreement:

(21) *[$_{\text{AgrsP}}$ Agrs[3SG] [$_{\text{vP}}$ …. DP1[3PL] … DP2[3SG] …]]

In this structure, the verbal agreement 3SG c-commands DP1 and DP2, and DP1 c-commands DP2 (but not vice versa). The verbal agreement only agrees with DP2, which is the furthest away. I predict that such a configuration is impossible. In other words, when (21) is interpreted at the interfaces, it is impossible for the verbal agreement 3SG to enter into a copy relation with DP2[3SG], because of the presence of the intervening DP1[3PL].

A concrete case of (21) would be verbal agreement with the object of a transitive verb (instead of the subject):

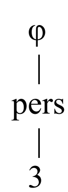
(22) a. *The boys see-s John.
b. *[$_{\text{AgrsP}}$ Agrs[3SG] [$_{\text{vP}}$ [the boys] … John]]]

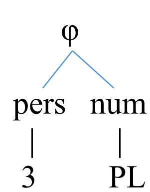
In this example, the verb agrees with the object, not the subject. Why is the agreement in (22) unacceptable? Why does DP1[3PL] block the copy relation between 3SG and DP2? After all, DP1 is 3PL, not 3SG, so it might seem that it should not block copy formation.

In order to answer the question, we need to be a little more concrete about the structure of verbal agreement 3SG. I assume that it has a hierarchical structure in which the different phi-features (e.g., SG, PL, PART, MASC, FEM) enter into a tree structure with a root node, which we can label φ (for 'phi'), following Preminger 2014: 46 and Storment 2024, amongst others.

(23) The phi-features of verbal agreement (Phi) are hierarchically structured.

Here are proposed structures for third person singular and third person plural verbal agreement (see Preminger 2014, Storment 2024, such structured representations are common in the agreement literature):

(24) a.


b.


When (21) is interpreted at the interfaces, the phi-feature φ unit 3SG enters into search for the nearest φ unit. The first one it finds is DP1, and so the search halts. Either DP1 has matching phi-features or not. In the context of my theory, 'matching' means identity. So the 3SG verbal agreement features do not match the features of DP[3PL], and no further search is allowed. Since the verbal agreement Agrs[3SG] cannot form a copy with DP1, the derivation violates Full Interpretation (see (16) above).

The generalization in (21) follows from minimal search. The assumption of this account is that the minimal search is defined by the highest node defining the set of phi-features, in this case φ. I leave for future work extending this approach to the cases involving "relativized" phi-probes in the sense of Deal 2023.

A short note on the role of minimal search in syntactic theory is in order.

Agree is also constrained by locality which is defined in terms of local c-command (Chomsky 2000: 122, 2001: 4). Even in an Agree based framework, there is no need to stipulate locality, because it falls under minimal search which is a principle of computational efficiency: the probe searches for the nearest matching goal. Principles of computational efficiency "…can be taken off the shelf when needed, with no cost." (Chomsky 2021: 12). As a principle of computational efficiency, minimal search plays a role in a wide variety of operations, such as finding a label (see Chomsky 2013: 43), searching members of the workspace for Merge (Chomsky 2021: 18) and establishing a copy relation (Chomsky 2021: 24, 35).

7. Late Insertion

On the theory of Agree in Chomsky 2001, the phi-features of the probe are initially unvalued. The phonological features of the probe can only be determined once the probe has its features valued. Concretely, it is only when the uPhi gets valued with 3SG that you know that it should be pronounced *-s* in English. Curiously, this minimalist conception of agreement dovetails closely with the Distributed Morphology claim that inflectional terminals get spelled-out in the morphological component by the insertion of vocabulary items.

On my analysis, neither set of phi-features in (14) is unvalued. Therefore, in this theory, there is no need for Late Insertion.

(25) There is no Late Insertion for phi-features.

Rather, the lexical item for 3SG agreement is simply: LI = {3SG, -s} (that is, LI = {FF, PF}, where FF = 'formal features' and PF = 'phonological form'). This lexical item is inserted by Merge like all other lexical items in the derivation (fully specified for phonological features). This conclusion is consistent with Collins and Kayne 2023, which eliminates Late Insertion more generally (not just for agreeing phi-features). In this sense, my approach to eliminating Agree falls under the general Morphology as Syntax (MaS) framework sketched in Collins and Kayne 2023.

8. Why Agreement?

I have argued that the operation Agree can be eliminated from UG. In its place, verbal agreement is introduced by external Merge and falls under the theory of copies and repetitions developed in Chomsky 2024. A possible objection could be that even though I have eliminated Agree, I have introduced other elements into the theory, such as the distinction between copies and repetitions, and the interpretation of copies and repetitions at the interfaces (copy formation). But that would be a mistake. All theories that employ Merge, with the accompanying distinction between internal and external Merge, will need to have a theory of copies versus repetitions. My claim is that once this theory is in place (see Collins 2017, Chomsky 2021, 2024), there is no need for an additional operation of Agree.

In fact, we can go one step further, and answer the following foundational question: Why does natural language have verbal agreement? The answer is that verbal agreement is accounted for in terms of external Merge (of the agreement morpheme) and the formation of copies at the interfaces. Since both of these components exist independently (external Merge, the formation of copies), we automatically expect to get verbal agreement, unless some additional stipulations are introduced to block it.

Chomsky 2021 refers to such a situation as the enabling function of SMT:

(26) "Less recognized is the fact that SMT also serves an enabling function. It provides options and systems for language that would have no reason to exist if language did not abide by SMT."

In the case at hand, a theory with Merge and copy formation distinction provides the components of verbal agreement, which otherwise has no reason to exist.

9. Loose Ends

There are many loose ends in my analysis.

I have said nothing about the relationship between Case and Agree, which was a major concern of Chomsky 2001. In particular, Chomsky 2001 argued that the goal of Agree with a uPhi probe had to have an unvalued uCase feature, which is valued as a "reflex" of Agree (called "goal flagging" in Deal 2023). On my approach, there are no unvalued phi-features. A stronger position would be that there are no unvalued features in general (including Case features). If so, the analysis of structural Case in Chomsky 2001 will have to be rethought.

I have not discussed whether or how Agree is connected to movement. A widespread approach in minimalist syntax is that once Agree(uPhi, DP) is established, then DP can move to Spec TP (triggered by an EPP feature). Nothing in my system either requires or precludes such an analysis (see also Chomsky 2013 on the role of agreement in labeling).

I have not been explicit about the theory of features I am adopting. I believe that the theory I am outlining would be equally compatible with a system based on privative features as well (see Storment 2024 for a fully worked out system), but I have not worked out the details.

I put aside discussion of agreement related phenomena such as nominal concord (e.g., agreement on an attributive adjective) and clitic doubling. It seems reasonable that both of these phenomena could be analyzed in the bare-bones theory of agreement proposed in this paper. The only difference between clitic doubling and verbal agreement is that a clitic would represent a bit more syntactic structure (perhaps containing a D layer in addition to Phi) than verbal agreement. Otherwise, the same mechanisms would apply.

Lastly, I have not addressed the arguments in Preminger (2014, 2018, 2021) against "filtration-based" approaches to agreement. In the current system, there are no unvalued features anymore, but as noted above, filtering still plays an important role. If there is a phi-feature mismatch between the verbal agreement features and the DP (see (16)), the verbal phi-features will not be interpreted as a copy, and there will be a violation of Full Interpretation. Therefore, it would be interesting to see how the key cases Preminger discusses come out in the current framework.

10. Conclusion

In this paper, I have argued for eliminating the operation of Agree. Agreement in natural language is instead analyzed in terms of external Merge of fully specified agreement morphemes and the theory of copies and repetitions developed in Chomsky 2024.

The theory of copies I adopt is the following (from Chomsky 2024):

(27) X and Y are copies iff
 a. X and Y are structurally identical.
 b. X c-commands Y.
 c. The relationship between X and Y obeys the PIC.

On the basis of this definition, I propose the following hypothesis:

(28) Verbal agreement is an externally merged Phi
 that is interpreted as a copy of the phi-features of a DP.

This proposal has the following theoretical consequences:

(29) a. There is no operation Agree in UG.
 b. There are no unvalued phi-features.
 c. There is no Late Insertion for phi-features.

Previous approaches to Agree have typically formulated a rather complex algorithm with many interlocking parts (see for example Deal 2023: 28, example (29)). One exciting feature of the current framework is that by decomposing the theory of verbal agreement (external Merge plus copy formation), it opens the way to understanding the properties of verbal agreement in terms of independent syntactic principles. For example, I noted above that the interpretation of verbal agreement is parallel to the interpretation of A-movement with scope reconstruction. I also noted that the issue of the spell-out of agreement might be related to the issue of the spell-out of lower copies in movement (see Kandybowicz 2007).

The literature on verbal agreement stemming from the Agree framework of Chomsky 2000, 2001 is by now quite extensive. It would be impossible for me to do it justice in such a short paper. By sketching the basics of the system eliminating Agree, I hope to stimulate further research along these lines.

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